

CHAPTER 11

Changing Protector Polarizations

So far, we have described how we use in-sight to help individual parts. We help exiles to be in relationship with the Self so they feel better, and we help protectors to see this healing effect and take on new roles. Nevertheless, some of our most important work involves changing the relationships between parts. In our experience, every client has polarized parts who maintain each other's extremes. On a continuum, parts in less polarized systems tend to be more cooperative and less in need of individual attention whereas highly polarized systems with warring parts require considerably more attention.

BURDENS BEGET POLARIZATIONS

When an event knocks a system off-balance, its members will try to restore balance, often by opposing each other. Parents become enemies, siblings become rivals, and parts who share the same overarching goal of warding off emotional pain often choose opposite strategies. Then each part fears backing down because the other will win. Paul Watzlawick and his colleagues (1974) used a nautical metaphor to describe these polarizations:

Two sailors [are] hanging out of either side of a sailboat in order to steady it: the more the one leans overboard, the more the other has to compensate for the instability created by other's attempts at stabilizing the boat, while the boat itself would be quite steady if not for their acrobatic efforts at steadying it. (p. 36)

When we apply this metaphor to the inner system, we can say that both sailors have left their preferred role for one that is so rigid, limited, and extreme it threatens to capsize the boat. As the sailors oppose each other, each must remain extreme to counter the behavior of the other, and each

can move only in relation to how the other moves. The irony of their position is that both wish for safe, smooth sailing, but agreement seems out of reach because they do not trust each other. They need a third party to help them get off the rails—a captain (the Self) whose authority both recognize. Once released from the constraints of their conflict, each sailor can move about the boat freely and play a valuable role, trusting the captain to steer a course that is safe and mutually beneficial.

Quinn's Polarities

Let's pursue this analogy with Quinn, the young woman from my ill-fated study on bulimia. Although Quinn moved out of her parents' home and was dating, she had many polarized parts. One voice, for example, continually pushed her to work, both at her job and at home. If Quinn sat still this striving part would call her *lazy* and remind her of many things that needed to be done. I guided Quinn to ask the striver what it was afraid would happen if it stopped running her to the point of exhaustion. The part replied that Quinn would get depressed and stay in bed. And, indeed, Quinn reported feeling depressed when she paused, which in turn caused her to stay in her apartment for days on end, withdrawing from work and friends entirely. "It's like the depression catches me when I slow down," she said.

After noticing the relationship between overwork and depression, Quinn interviewed her depressed part, who complained that the striver was domineering. As a result, it said, it had to seize any opening to bring Quinn to a grinding halt and hold her down. As soon as it let go, the striver would reclaim her, obliterating all sad thoughts and feelings with excessive busyness. Thus, each part feared the influence of the other, and both were deadlocked in extremity. Neither could deescalate unless both were sure the other would follow suit.

Lacking the systemic awareness we are describing here, Quinn's other therapist offered a commonsense prescription that inadvertently sided with Quinn's depressed part: "Instead of running yourself ragged, try slowing down." In response, her striving part worked harder. When family, friends, and therapists don't understand the polarized nature of inner conflict, they often make the mistake of siding with the part who seems to them to make the most sense. Just like individuals who are negotiating in a family, or countries that are negotiating internationally, many parts cannot and will not change unilaterally, and they also will not trust someone who sides against them. By understanding the relational context of extreme parts, we lay the groundwork for effective intervention.

Rapid Escalation in Polarizations

In a polarization even small differences can escalate quickly. The more Quinn excluded her depressed part, the more it pushed the sense of depression and hopelessness; the more depressed that part got, the more the striver strove to exile it, and so on. This ubiquitous feedback loop is central to systems thinking. We can help parts depolarize by introducing them to each other and letting them hear their false assumptions about each other, emphasizing that neither intends harm and both aim to solve the same underlying problem. In this case, the depressed part was a 6-year-old who protected a lonely, scared 5-year-old. The depressed part was trying to get Quinn's attention for the 5-year-old by pinning her down, while the striver was trying to keep Quinn away from the lonely fears of the 5-year-old and also the depression.

When Quinn introduced the striver and the depressed part to each other, they softened. But before they could leave their jobs they needed to know that Quinn's Self was taking care of the 5-year-old. Once the 5-year-old could get the attention, influence, and resources that the young Quinn needed, the sad part and the striver would be able to relax. In IFS therapy balance and harmony are intricately linked objectives, with balance producing the necessary conditions for harmony. Fortunately, the Self is a capable captain. Once the depressed part (an exiled protector) and the 5-year-old (an exile) separated enough to get Quinn's attention, they crawled into her lap to rest and cuddle. Their relational resurrection brought a new level of contentment and energy to Quinn's life. Seeing this, the striver stopped pushing and shifted to setting reasonable goals and helping strategize to achieve them.

For the IFS therapist, the client's internal and external worlds comprise one large system that operates according to the same principles and is responsive to the same therapeutic techniques. For example, Quinn's internal family reflected the values and structure of her external family. As her parents became independent of her, Quinn's Self helped her system to develop better inner boundaries and took care of the parts who feared losing her parents. Change at one level does not necessarily produce parallel change at other levels, but it does shake things up across system levels and create an opportunity for productive change. When the client's external situation is unsafe to begin with, however, we recommend caution. Change that moves across system levels can put this client in danger, so keep an eye out and address external safety issues throughout the therapy. If the client is safe, we can go to whichever system level she chooses, knowing that we can shift levels as needed.

Burdens Resulting from Trauma

Family dynamics and bias are not alone in creating burdens. When people get rejected, neglected, abandoned, shocked, scared, or abused (physically, sexually, or emotionally), their injured parts are quickly sequestered and their inner systems polarize. We can testify that numerous traumatized clients have taught IFS practitioners about the kinds of burdening, [imbalance](#), and polarization that typically result from trauma. When a human system—be it individual, family, community, or country—suffers a threat or an overwhelming trauma, it organizes to protect its leadership and its most vulnerable members. For example, if one country threatens another, the threatened country will move its leaders to a safe place. At the same time, civilians will be sent to shelters, and the military will take over. If the leader stays calm, providing a sense of strength and comfort while the crisis is resolved, the public's trust in the leader is likely to increase. In contrast, the leader who is not able to prevent devastating losses will lose credibility, and the military will likely stay in power.

Internal families operate the same way. Let's consider an inner family that includes members of various ages and degrees of vulnerability. In the face of danger, the family moves the Self as well as the system's most vulnerable parts to safety while protective parts step forward. Traumatized clients have taught us that before or during trauma the inner family separates the Self from the sensations of the body to varying degrees (depending on how severe they judge the danger to be)—sometimes pushing it out of the body altogether—and some of the older members take control to protect the system with fight-or-flight responses: lashing out or escaping while more vulnerable parts freeze. These front-line protectors aim to minimize sensations of terror and pain for the system and the Self.

Despite these efforts, the youngest, most vulnerable members of the inner family are powerfully affected by traumatic events. They feel injury, abandonment, and betrayal acutely. When the stimulus is intense enough, vulnerable parts freeze in time and experience a kind of endless Groundhog Day repetition of the trauma, complete with all of its sensations and feelings. By contrast, if the Self can stay embodied and offer immediate assistance, the system's trust in Self-leadership increases, building inner strength and opposing tendencies to polarize, all of which helps injured parts avoid being exiled and instead stay in the stream of time.

Although Self-leadership throughout a crisis is ideal, the Self cannot always lead during trauma. If the victim is an infant or child, much depends on the reactions of those around her. For example, when a child is returned to safety, comforted, loved, and helped to understand and accept what happened, her Self will also stay available, and will respond to hurt parts inside with love, comfort, and acceptance. In the best-case scenario, the child's experience is validated, and injured parts unburden spontaneously. If, however, the Self is impotent to protect the system and cannot help traumatized parts after the fact, the inner family will lose trust and become overprotective of both the

Self and injured parts. In this case, protectors will come to dominate the inner system just as parentified children dominate dysfunctional families, leaving the client with little or no access to her Self.

Nevertheless, it is a fundamental error to conclude that such a person has no Self. The IFS maxim that all people have a Self that cannot be damaged invites us to stay curious and present with all manner of collapse in our clients. Even when the Self is separated from the body, we can be confident that the resources of the Self exist. If this concept is difficult for the reader, it may help to think of ancient responses to a solar eclipse: When the moon obscured the sun, people feared that the sun was gone forever. Likewise, with the Self in eclipse after trauma, we fear that the sun is gone. It feels as if we are psychically homeless and disconnected from life, as if our spirit is missing, or we have actually died and are now just going through the motions of living. In IFS therapy, we aim to end the eclipse.

PROTECTORS GET POLARIZED

Managers suppress exiled feelings while firefighters distract from them. These two classes of protectors often polarize over how to keep the client safe and make life tolerable. When we notice a polarity, we talk to the parts involved to find out how they activate each other. And we ask what they fear would happen if they stopped quarreling so we could address the underlying problem, which boils down to a legacy burden or the emotional suffering of an exile. Polarized parts can be stubborn. [Box 11.1](#) lists some of what motivates polarized parts to dig in and what helps them to deescalate.

BOX 11.1. Why Protectors Polarize and How to De-Escalate Them

WHY PROTECTORS POLARIZE

- # Polarized protectors share a common problem—the vulnerability of the exile—but are in conflict over how best to handle it.
- # A manager who becomes extreme in one direction generates another manager or a firefighter who is extreme in another direction.

HOW WE HELP PROTECTORS DE-ESCALATE

1. Polarized protectors are more likely to cooperate and de-escalate when we include both sides and favor neither.
2. We ask these parts to meet each other, appreciate what they have in common, and try trusting the Self to take care of the exile they protect.

3. If they agree, we introduce them to the third party—the client's Self—who can solve their problem.
4. Even after meeting the Self, intensely polarized protectors often need to de-escalate simultaneously because they will not risk deescalating unilaterally (Krause et al., 2016).
5. Sometimes it is better for the Self to establish a trusting relationship with each part before bringing them together.

Following is an example of negotiating with polarized protectors. Charlotte is 38 years old and works long hours at a big tech company. She has come to therapy because she feels depressed.

THERAPIST: Where do you notice the depression?

CHARLOTTE: I have a crowded head.

THERAPIST: How do you feel toward your crowded head?

CHARLOTTE: Tired.

THERAPIST: Is it okay to be curious about it?

CHARLOTTE: I'll tell you what it is. I have no life because I work too much.

THERAPIST: You have no life?

CHARLOTTE: Well, actually the problem isn't work. It's watching Netflix till 2:00 A.M.!

THERAPIST: Sounds like you're of two minds about what the problem is.

CHARLOTTE: It's really that I'm working from 7:00 A.M. till 10:00 P.M.

THERAPIST: I see what you mean about a crowded head.

[The therapist recognizes a polarization.]

CHARLOTTE: I admit I should leave earlier, but sometimes I just can't. If I got more sleep, working late on occasion wouldn't be a problem.

THERAPIST: So one part of you is okay with long work hours, but wants you to get more sleep and not watch TV. Is that right?

[The therapist names the parts in the polarization.]

CHARLOTTE: I can't stand working this way anymore. I'm exhausted. I hate it.

THERAPIST: That's the part who does not like long work hours.

CHARLOTTE: I should just cancel cable. Then I'd have no choice about going to sleep when I get home.

THERAPIST: That's the other part. Do you notice these two parts, Charlotte?

[Rather than letting the parts continue to argue, the therapist addresses Charlotte to see if she has enough space to observe them.]

CHARLOTTE: I guess so.

THERAPIST: How do you feel toward them?

CHARLOTTE: I am curious about this fight in my head!

[Sounds like enough Self to proceed.]

THERAPIST: Ask the one who watches TV at night what would happen if it stopped?

CHARLOTTE: I'd never get a break.

THERAPIST: Okay. Now ask the one who wants you to keep working this hard what would happen if it stopped pushing you?

CHARLOTTE: I'd never get ahead.

THERAPIST: And then what?

CHARLOTTE: I'd be a failure.

THERAPIST: And then what?

[The therapist tracks the sequence of beliefs that motivates the hardworking part, which will eventually reveal the exile.]

CHARLOTTE: I'd be worthless!

THERAPIST: So this one is protecting you from a part who feels worthless?

[The therapist does not try to reassure the client about feeling worthless, which is a burden. To address burdens, the client's Self must have a relationship with the exile, which will come later.]

CHARLOTTE: I guess I do sometimes.

THERAPIST: If we could help the part who feels worthless, would you need to work this hard?

[Now the therapist tracks back from the exile to the extreme behaviors of the client's protectors.]

CHARLOTTE: Probably not.

THERAPIST: And if you didn't work this hard would you watch TV late into the night?

CHARLOTTE: I'm sure I wouldn't.

THERAPIST: So would these two parts let you help the one who feels worthless?

[The therapist requests permission to help the exile.]

CHARLOTTE: How am I supposed to do that?

THERAPIST: If no one objects I'll show you.

CHARLOTTE: I'm hearing *okay*.

THERAPIST: So where do you notice the worthless feeling in or around your body?

CHARLOTTE: It's a tiny speck far away in the middle of my body.

THERAPIST: How do you feel toward it?

CHARLOTTE: I want it to stay there—far away.

THERAPIST: Who said that?

CHARLOTTE: I think that was the hardworking part.

THERAPIST: Was it?

CHARLOTTE: Yes.

THERAPIST: Does the hardworking part see you?

[Rather than trying to convince the hardworking part of the benefits of allowing the client's Self to help the exile, the therapist focuses on introducing the hardworking part to the Self.]

CHARLOTTE: No.

THERAPIST: Would it like to see you?

CHARLOTTE: Okay.

THERAPIST: How does it respond?

CHARLOTTE: It's surprised.

THERAPIST: Would it be willing to trust you?

CHARLOTTE: Maybe.

THERAPIST: We only need it to trust you far enough to try something new.

[The therapist accepts the hardworking part's caution and is persistent.]

CHARLOTTE: Okay.

THERAPIST: So go back to noticing that speck. How do you feel toward it now?

CHARLOTTE: I feel kind, I guess. I want to help.

THERAPIST: Let it know.

CHARLOTTE: It's getting bigger.

THERAPIST: Is that all right?

CHARLOTTE: Yes. It's like a bean now. Or maybe an embryo!

THERAPIST: What does it need from you?

[The therapist directs the part toward relationship with the Self.]

CHARLOTTE: Protection.

THERAPIST: So what needs to happen?

[The therapist facilitates the client's Self in taking the lead.]

CHARLOTTE: I'm putting it in a globe of golden light. It likes that.

THERAPIST: Shall we come back to it next week?

CHARLOTTE: Yes.

Charlotte has a part who works too many hours and a part who responds by zoning out in front of the TV late into the night. Since the excesses of the hardworking part initiate this cycle, the therapist

asks about its fears. In response, the client names the exile's burden: the belief that it is worthless and the feeling of worthlessness. Once the exile's burden has been named, the therapist offers to help. Note that the therapist did not talk to the hardworking part about the drawbacks of being excessive, and did not admonish the TV-watching part because the therapist assumed that they would both dismiss all collateral damage as a necessary evil, preferable to Charlotte's being overwhelmed with exiled feelings. So the therapist offered to solve the problem of exiled feelings.

Once the client signs on for helping the exile, the table is set for witnessing and unburdening, though by the next week Charlotte's protectors may have thought better of allowing things to move so quickly—in which case they will throw up roadblocks and the therapy will slow down for awhile. As this example illustrates, polarized protectors are invariably motivated by something internal (a fear of feelings) that may be quite obscure to others. When the client addresses this underlying motive, however, they pay attention and eventually (though not always this quickly) cooperate.

Inner Triangles Produce Vicious Cycles

As we've illustrated, protectors polarize around how to cope best with the raw pain of exiles. Their patterned behaviors settle into vicious cycles that escalate over time, pushing all three categories of parts involved into ever-greater extremity. For example, suppose Suzanna has an exile who believes she is unlovable (a shaming belief). In response, one of her firefighters leads her to bars to binge drink. And in response to that behavior a manager berates her constantly for being weak and indulgent, shaming her for what she's doing to her body and her family, and urging her to exert some willpower to stop. Her family and her therapist also try to shame her into stopping. Unfortunately all this inner and outer shaming makes her burdened exile feel even more desperate, which has the effect of encouraging the firefighter to take her out drinking, and so on (for more on this cycle in drug and alcohol addiction, see Cece Sykes's chapter, "An IFS Lens on Addiction: Compassion for Extreme Parts," in the book *Innovations and Elaborations in Internal Family Systems Therapy* [2016]). Since our culture sets great stock in willpower, most of our addiction problems are locked into some version of this vicious cycle.

PROTECTOR–EXILE RELATIONSHIPS VERSUS PROTECTOR–P ROTECTOR POLARITIES

Extreme protector behaviors denote extreme exile despair, pain, terror, and shame. That is, the extremity of the protector is commensurate with the vulnerability of the exile. The way in which the

exile's feelings instigate fierce, bifurcated tactics on the part of protectors illustrates the natural tendency of any system to try to stay balanced. Since every extreme tactic is potentially unbalancing, protectors try to counterbalance each other. For example, a workaholic part (a manager) and an alcoholic part (a firefighter) maintain balance, though only at the cost of escalation. Managers can polarize with each other, too. For example, one manager from early childhood might focus on being a good, compliant child, while an older manager is focused on getting ahead financially, which requires more assertion and less compliance. The increasingly unhappy results of extremely polarized behaviors are basically a side effect of a battle for control. The escalating tactics of polarized protectors are like two kinds of medicine that work quickly but interfere with each other, necessitating ever-higher doses, which endanger the patient.

When protectors are highly critical of each other, or of the exiles they protect, it can be hard to differentiate between a protector polarity and a protector–exile relationship. Nevertheless, these relationships call for different therapeutic tactics, so being mindful of the difference is useful. When we are dealing with a protector polarity, we have a trio of parts (one of who, the exile, is often hidden) and we go through a two-step process. The first step is to ask the two warring protectors to stand down. Once they agree (which can take time) we ask them to let the client's Self access the exile. On the other hand, when we are dealing with just one protector and an exile, we have a dyad and a one-step process in which we ask the protector to relax back so the exile can move forward and meet the Self. If we mistake the exile for a polarized protector and ask it to relax back (as we would a protector) expecting to find an exile underneath, we run the risk of giving the actual exile the message that it is not wanted. This mistake can cause a puzzling escalation of symptoms while slowing the therapy down. For these reasons it is important to differentiate protector polarities from protector–exile relationships. We can do so easily with a simple, revealing question: *Who do you protect?* If the part says *No one*, it is an exile.

DISARMING A POLARIZATION: THE CONFERENCE TABLE TECHNIQUE

We disarm polarizations by promoting direct communication between polarized parts (see [Box 11.2](#)). Although polarized parts are aware of each other and vie to influence the client, they may never have interacted directly, and they rarely comprehend that they protect the same part. As long as they

are isolated from each other, their prejudices are confirmed by mutually extreme behaviors. But when they finally meet, they often resolve long-standing conflicts and develop a new relationship quickly.

BOX 11.2. Helping Stubbornly Polarized Parts

- # We can help the client's Self orchestrate a simultaneous unblending.
- # We can suggest that each part be given the opportunity to do more individual work.
- # We can have polarized parts meet repeatedly until they have heard enough to be less extreme in each other's presence.
- # We are persistent; we keep these parts engaged.
- # We convey the expectation that they will find a way forward if they listen to each other.

We therefore aim to help parts hear and see each other realistically. Using a technique called the *conference table*, which was developed 20 or so years ago by Michi Rose, my (RS) early collaborator in the development of IFS, we invite all of the parts who are involved with the problem under examination to sit down at a table with the client's Self, which will act as their referee and keep the conversation respectful. Once everyone involved comes to (or near) the table, we guide the client's Self to preface the dialogue between parts with a statement something like this, *I know you both want something good for everyone inside—but you differ about how to make that happen. I can help, but first I want you to listen to each other. Or, Your battles are self-defeating because you share the same goals, though you have different methods. I doubt you're aware of this. I promise that we can resolve the underlying problem—all that pain and vulnerability—in a way that will satisfy both of you. So let's start by hearing from each of you.* The Self can also preface the meeting with information about each part's true nature, serving as the hope merchant for this small subsystem and explaining how much better things would be for them if they understood each other. In many cases polarized parts can then talk with minimal input from the Self.

However, if one or both parts are recalcitrant and will not discuss the issues in good faith, the Self should insist on them at least being respectful and listening to each other. Sometimes these efforts do not bear fruit immediately and nothing gets resolved in a single session. We may suggest that each part be given the opportunity to do more individual work, or that the parts meet with each other repeatedly until they have heard enough to be less extreme in each other's presence. Whichever tactic seems most suitable to the pair, the idea is to be persistent, keep the parts engaged, and convey the expectation that listening to each other will ultimately help. During this conversation, the

therapist is in the copilot seat, suggesting questions like those that follow, and focusing on making sure that the client's Self remains differentiated.

- Who has been taking the most leadership?
- Who has been helping whom?
- Who is in conflict with whom?
- Who is most upset?
- What does everyone think needs to happen today?

If the group reports that one part remains extreme and needs a new role, the Self can interview that part, asking group members for help in maintaining the negotiated change. If the problem is a disagreement between two parts, the Self can ask those two to face each other and talk while the rest of the group watches. When a part needs help, the Self explores what kind of help and asks for volunteers. If the client faces a problem, the Self invites the group to devise a plan to address the problem. If the client faces an important decision, the Self convenes the group and asks parts to consider the pros and cons of the options favored by various parts. After listening, the Self makes the final decision and asks parts who did not “win” what they might need.

After these conversations, dramatic reversals in conflicted inner relationships are not uncommon. For example, I (RS) have witnessed a manager who despised a young part reverse its behavior completely, choosing to become a role model and mentor for this child. To monitor how parts are reacting and uncover any developing polarities as the group proceeds, the Self can also ask these questions:

- Who is upset by this discussion?
- Who might be inclined to interfere with this decision?
- Who wants to follow through with this decision?
- How would you all prefer to relate to each other going forward?

As this description illustrates, IFS therapy with polarities can run the gamut from individual to dyadic, triadic, or inner group (which is to say family) therapy. As we resolve polarities, our overarching goal is to reorganize inner relationships in general so that parts trust and help one another. When we assist and support an internal family in this way, the group often takes over and functions on its own, sometimes without the Self even being aware. I have seen the Self call a meeting only to find that the parts involved had already handled that problem and moved on to other issues. In my experience, most changes happen within the group, apart from the Self. This kind of

inner group process is a great benefit to clients since it brings all of their resources to bear on problems as soon as they arise. In other words, the client can foster a well-functioning inner group that pools resources, debates decisions, and trusts its leadership much as happens in healthy external systems.

CONCLUSION

Protectors get into conflict all the time. The more traumatized an inner system, the more polarities are likely to have developed. Protector polarizations are ubiquitous and flag the existence of exiles. Our job is not to decide who is right in any given polarity, but to find out what would happen if they stopped doing their jobs—a question that reveals the exile. Once we find the exile, the client's Self can offer to solve that problem (that is, to meet the exile's needs). And once the exile is healed we can expect polarizations to melt like ice in the sun.